The graphics objects in a document can be divided into two classes:

- The real content of a document comprises objects representing material originally introduced by the document's author.
- Artifacts[1] are graphics objects that are not part of the author's original content but rather are generated by the conforming writer in the course of pagination, layout, or other strictly mechanical processes.

[1] Artifacts may also be used to describe areas of the document where the author uses a graphical background, with the goal of enhancing the visual experience. In such a case, the background is not required for understanding the content.